Unit 7. Sharing the gospel (Action)

Overview

This unit builds on the previous one. It helps you to put that reflection on the nature of the gospel into practice through teaching motives and methods for sharing the gospel.

Outline

- Introduction
- Why should we share the gospel?
  - The rule of God
  - The love of God
  - The justice of God
- How can we share the gospel?
  - A testimony to share
  - A message to communicate
  - A change to demonstrate
- Conclusion

Outcomes

By the end of the unit you will be able to

1. Name and then internalise clear motives for sharing the gospel
2. Share the story of what God has done in your life in a way that communicates the heart of the gospel
3. Use a simple framework to explain the gospel to others

7.1 INTRODUCTION

Begin by discussing these questions:

- What motivates you to share the good news of Jesus with other people?

- What hinders us in our desire and ability to share the gospel with others?

7.2 WHY SHOULD WE SHARE THE GOSPEL?

7.2.1 The rule of God

We have already learnt that the gospel is based on the fact that God is in charge of the world – he is the one who has purposes, makes plans and is able to follow through on them. Paul uses the phrase “our Lord” (2 Tim 1:8) when talking about Jesus; Jesus rules God’s world and has the right to rule our lives. Paul commands Timothy to preach the word “in view of his appearing and his kingdom” (2 Tim 4:1).

We also learnt that the gospel is for everyone. God’s rule means it is for everyone. It is a public message and God’s church is designed to be a public address system – God’s way of letting the whole world know the message and implications of the gospel. In other words the rule of God means that the gospel is relevant and important for everyone – we have to share it and share it well. There are far too many faulty public address systems. We need to make sure that our church is faultless in proclaiming the gospel clearly.

7.2.2 The love of God

- Think of some good news you have received. What did you do once you had received it?

The Pastoral Epistles connect God’s gospel with God’s love. For example Paul talks of when the “kindness and love of God our saviour appeared” (Titus 3:4). The gospel is the good news of God’s love; that good news is for sharing. It is as simple as that. The gospel speaks of God’s love for us and transforms us to love others. The most loving thing we can do is to share the gospel of God’s love with them.

7.2.3 The justice of God

The gospel is a message of both God’s love *and* God’s justice – 2 Tim 4:1 talks of “Christ Jesus, who will judge the living and the dead”. It is a reminder that our wrongdoing deserves punishment, but that in love Christ bears that shame and punishment himself. But if people do not trust Christ to do that for them, they will have to face the consequences one day, not least because of the rule of God.

This is good news, because God will not allow sin, including injustice, to go unpunished. But it is bad news in that it is a solemn warning for all people everywhere.

7.3 HOW CAN WE SHARE THE GOSPEL?

7.3.1 A testimony to share

We have discussed the different words we use for the activity of sharing the gospel with others. The idea of 'testimony' may have come up. A testimony is the presentation of evidence by a witness. When you are giving a testimony you are telling your story of what Christ has done in your life – it is a testimony about Christ. 1 Timothy 1:12-17 is a fine example of this, read that passage before you go any further.

Prepare well
You will find it much easier to relax and be yourself if you are well prepared. Give time to preparing your story and make sure the length serves the listener.

Use a structure
It is easiest to follow this simple structure:

1. Before – explain what life was like before you met Christ. You may have been brought up in a Christian home and Jesus has always been a friend of the family. Do not invent a troubled past if you do not have one, but make it clear that you had to come to a point where you made a decision yourself about Christ.

2. During – how did you come to meet Christ and make that decision? What were the circumstances and who was influential. What got you thinking and what did it involve? All our stories are different, but make it clear that God calls us to turn away from our wrong doing and self-centredness and to turn to him as our only hope.

3. After – what difference has it made? Be realistic about the ups and downs of the Christian life, but use examples of how Christ's love and God's promises have made a difference to you and those around you.

Avoid 'jargon'
Technical, theological or complicated words not only put people off the gospel but fail to communicate it. For example talk about rebellion and disobedience rather than 'sin'. Explain that we need to turn away from self and to God rather than 'repent'. Say that we need to rely on what God has done in Christ, rather than our own efforts rather than 'faith'.

Practice on a Christian friend
It will help you and encourage your Christian friend if you can practice your testimony. You might want to do that now in pairs:

> **Step 1.** Person A: spend 5 minutes sharing your testimony with Person B
>
> **Step 2.** Person B: comment on the testimony that you have just heard. For example, what was clear about it and what was not?
>
> **Step 3.** Reverse the process. Person B: spend 5 minutes sharing your testimony with Person A.
>
> **Step 4.** Person A: comment on the testimony that you have just heard. For example, what was clear about it and what was not?

Pray
Evangelism, sharing the gospel, is what we do. Changing lives is what God does. We must pray that he will help us and will speak to our friends and contacts.

7.3.2 A message to communicate

Paul tells us that the gospel is “the power of God for the salvation of everyone who believes” (Romans 1:16). God’s good news is a life changing message. We need to be able to communicate it simply and explain it deeply. That depth will develop as we go through the BUILD modules.

Communicating the good news to others
We will begin by assessing the way in which we are already communicating the gospel to other people. We will follow a similar process to the one we used to help us share our testimonies with the aim of evaluating the message we are sharing and the way in which we are explaining it. Follow the four steps below:

> **Step 1.** Person A: Spend 5 minutes explaining the gospel, as you understand it, to Person B.
>
> **Step 2.** Person B: Comment on the explanation of the gospel that you have just heard from Person A. For example, what was clear about it and what was not?
>
> **Step 3.** *Now reverse the process.* Person B: Spend 5 minutes explaining the gospel, as you understand it, to Person A.
>
> **Step 4.** Person A: Comment on the explanation of the gospel that you have just heard from Person B. For example, what was clear about it and what was not?

You might want to comment on your explanations in the light of the passages about the gospel that we have already looked at in the Pastoral Epistles.

Communicating the gospel using BUILD’s 3-2-1 method
There are many different ways of explaining the good news. BUILD’s 3-2-1 outline has been designed for BUILD learners. It is built on and will build on your learning. It is based on 1 Timothy 1:15-17. Take time to learn this short passage by heart if you have not done so already. It is presented below in a way that will help you to memorise it:

15 Here is a trustworthy saying that deserves full acceptance:
Christ Jesus came into the world to save sinners – of whom I am the worst.

16 But for that very reason I was shown mercy so that in me, the worst of sinners,
Christ Jesus might display his immense patience as an example
for those who would believe in him and receive eternal life.

17 Now to the King eternal, immortal, invisible, the only God,
be honour and glory for ever and ever. Amen.

We are calling this method 3-2-1 so that we know what we are referring to and to make this presentation of the gospel easy to remember. It is called 3-2-1 because in 1 Timothy 1:15-17 there are:

> **3** things to understand, **2** things to do and **1** way to live

3 things to understand:

1. God is King

God is "the King eternal, immortal, invisible, the only God" (verse 17). God is King and is in charge of everything and everyone. He always has been and always will be because he alone is "eternal." God is not like us. He is "immortal" and "invisible." He is unique, "the only God." We have been created to give him "honour and glory." That means recognising who he is and living to please him.

- Do you understand that God is King and that you should obey him?

2. We are sinners

God made us to love and obey him, but we live for our own honour and glory. That is why Paul calls people "sinners" and feels he is the "worst of sinners" (verses 15 and 16). No one likes to be called a sinner, but Paul has just told us that God loves us very much (verse 14). However, despite and because of his great love for us, God cannot stand our sin and we cannot approach him. This leads to death, a problem that only God can solve.

- Do you understand that you are a sinner and are cut off from God?

3. Jesus came to save us

This good news is at the heart of the "trustworthy saying": "Christ Jesus came into the world to save sinners" (verse 15). If we understand our guilt, shame and powerlessness we know we need a saviour. The title "Christ Jesus" means 'God's chosen rescuer.' God the King came in the person of his Son, and his death and resurrection completed his mission. At the cross Jesus dealt with sin and evil once and for all. He is the saviour that we need and that God sends.

- Do you understand that Christ Jesus is the only one who can rescue you?

2 things to do:

1. Believe in Jesus

Verse 16 reminds us that God has done all the work but that we need to respond: we must "believe in him." That is Paul's way of telling us to trust what God has already done for us through Jesus Christ. The gospel is "a trustworthy saying that deserves full acceptance" and we must put our hope fully in Jesus, the only one who can rescue us.

- Will you put your trust fully in Jesus to save you?

2. Receive new life

Verse 16 goes on to tell us that as we trust in God we "receive eternal life." The King removes our sin and shame and welcomes us into his kingdom, a place with no evil and no end. That life begins now through the gift of God's Holy Spirit but it continues beyond the grave and into the future, when God's new heavens and new earth will be established forever. We must open our hearts to receive God's great gift.

- Will you open your heart to receive God's gift of new life?

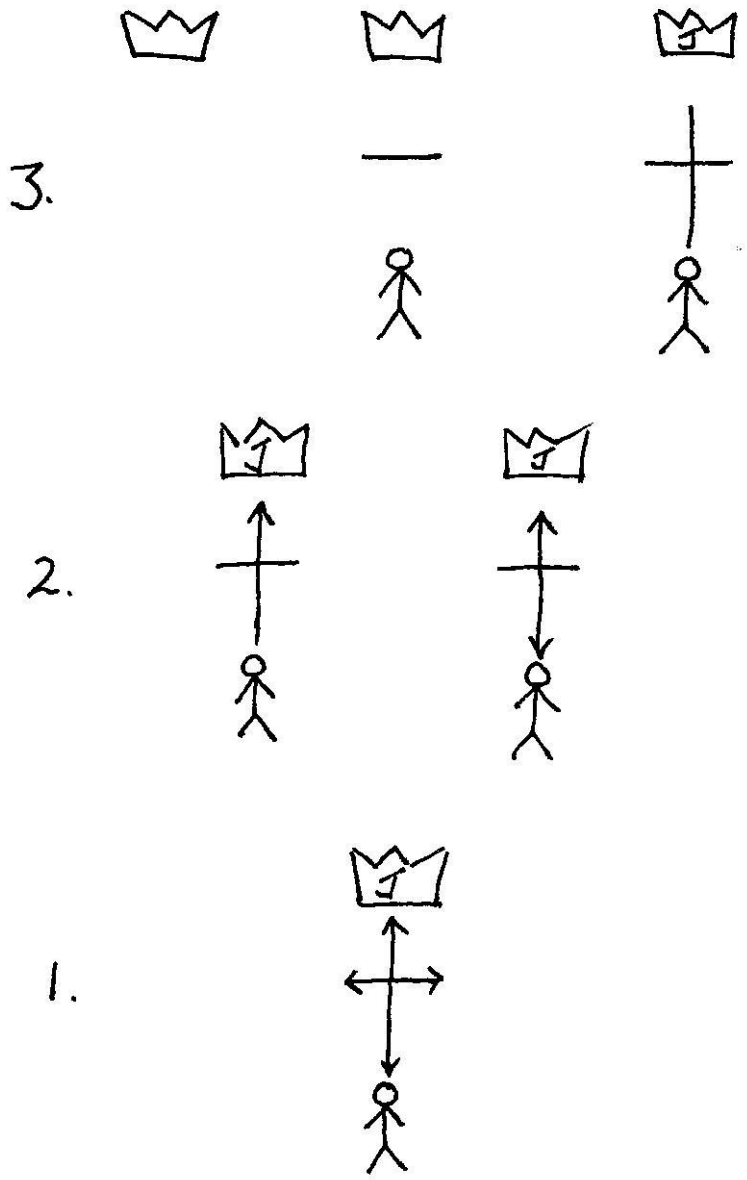
1 way to live:

Live God's way

Believing in Jesus and receiving God's Holy Spirit is just the start. We must live God's way from now on. The passage ends, "Now to the King eternal, immortal, invisible, the only God, be honour and glory for ever and ever. Amen." Paul learnt to love, honour and obey God, and we must do the same. That means loving others and living for God.

- Will you turn from sin and evil and live God's way from now on?

Picturing the gospel using the 3-2-1 method
You can use some very simple pictures to illustrate and explain the 3-2-1 outline. You can either draw these as six separate pictures or build up one picture as you go along:



<u>3 things to understand</u> - in the first row of pictures:
- The first picture is a crown, to show that God is King.
- The second shows us under God's rule, but as sinners, separate from him.
- The third points out that Jesus is our saviour: he died for the sins of the world.

<u>2 things to do</u> - in the second row:
- In the first picture the arrow points up: we must believe in Jesus.
- In the second the arrow also points down: we receive life through the Holy Spirit.

<u>1 way to live</u> - in the third row:
- All the arrows in the picture point outwards: we must live our lives God's way.

Other ideas for using the 3-2-1 method to explain the good news:

1. Ask the person you are with for permission to share a brief explanation of the good news from the Bible for you to discuss together. Many people have rejected a false presentation of the gospel and have never considered a true one.

2. Read out the passage at the beginning and keep referring to it. That will help people to see that you are not inventing a message and that your authority comes from the Bible.

3. Go through the presentation by making the statements, providing the explanations and asking the questions. Build out the statements with further explanation. You do not have to follow the exact text of the 3-2-1 method given above. Adapt it for your setting using your own language. Use what you learnt in Unit 6 to help you.

4. Repeat the presentation with the pictures if it is easy and natural to do so. You do not have to introduce the pictures of your presentation at the beginning or to use them at all. But they can provide a way of reinforcing the message if you want to use them.

5. Use other parts of 1 Timothy to shed more light on the message, again, if it is easy and natural to do so. For example:

> 1 Timothy 6:15-16 reinforces and develops the main idea of 1:17: God is King. It uses a number of phrases to do so. For example, “King of kings and Lord of lords,” is based on Old Testament texts that emphasise God’s sovereignty (Ezekiel 26:7 and Daniel 2:37) and his power over all other ‘gods’ (Deuteronomy 10:17 and Psalm 136:2-3). The fact that he dwells in “unapproachable light” (Psalm 104:2) reminds us of his purity.
>
> 1 Timothy 3:16 explains more about Jesus’ saving mission: his becoming flesh, his global recognition and his glorious ascension.
>
> 1 Timothy 2:5-6 tells us more about Jesus’ role as our mediator and ransom through his death.
>
> 1 Timothy 6:14 explains that Jesus will appear again: no one will escape his claim on their lives.
>
> 1 Timothy 4:10 uses the idea of putting “our hope in the living God” as another way of describing belief. It tells us that we do that by placing our trust in him through Jesus, “the Saviour of all people”. It also helps us to understand that while God can save everyone and anyone, he only saves “those who believe”.

Using 3-2-1 to not only explain the gospel but to lead someone to Christ:

People need to not only understand the gospel but also to respond to it. Repentance and faith is the response God requires: people must turn away from sin and evil and turn to Christ. That change is demonstrated in lives lived God’s way. The explanation of ‘two things to do’ and ‘one way to live’ underlines the importance of that.

3-2-1 not only explains the content of gospel, it gives a natural opportunity to challenge people to follow Jesus themselves. You can help someone to begin to follow Jesus by turning the content of 3-2-1 into a prayer like this one:

> Heavenly Father, I recognise that you are King. I have been living in your world but I have not been living in your way. Thank you for sending Jesus to be my saviour. I trust in him alone for my salvation and receive the gift of life that your Holy Spirit brings. From now on I want to live for Jesus until I meet him face to face in his new world. Thank you for the gift of your Holy Spirit, who will strengthen me to live life your way from now on. In Jesus' name I pray. Amen.

You can adjust the content of the prayer for the situation of the listener or group.

The strengths and weaknesses of different ways of sharing the gospel
Any short explanation of the gospel will have its strengths and weaknesses. You can make up for any shortcomings that you think this presentation has. Remember that even Jesus and Paul explained the same gospel in different ways in different places. You need to tailor your explanation to your setting. For example, you can explain that the single figure of the individual can also represent mankind as a whole: we were made for relationship with one another. And while each of us, alone, must make a decision, the good news has an impact on all our relationships and leads to a new community, the local church.

7.3.3 A change to demonstrate

The Pastoral Epistles make it clear that the message of the gospel is also to be communicated through our lives, which demonstrate the change that Christ brings. In other words there is also to be non-verbal communication.

- Titus 2:1-10 draws attention to this aspect of evangelism. Look through that passage and discuss the link between the message of the gospel and lives that reinforce the message.

- Do our lives demonstrate the impact of the gospel in a similar way? In what ways does this challenge you, individually, and your church or churches?

7.4 CONCLUSION

Review the motivations for sharing the gospel: the rule, love and justice of God. Review the methods for sharing the gospel: sharing our testimony, explaining the message, demonstrating the change the gospel brings.

End the session in prayer, asking for God to open the eyes of our hearts to see and understand his kingdom of love and justice and to help us to share his good news, not least as we "make the teaching about God our Saviour attractive" (Titus 2:10).

7.5 EXTRA: THE DIFFERENT WORDS FOR SHARING THE GOSPEL

- What words or expressions do you use for the activity of sharing the gospel? What words do others use? What do they mean?

We have been talking about the activity of sharing the gospel. Paul himself uses different words and phrases for this. Your trainer will guide your responses to the question above to help you in your learning.